

There's an old beer commercial in which a couple is driving down a dark country road and they spot a hitchhiker with a case of beer and a live chainsaw. The driver wants to pick up the hitchhiker because he advertises something he wants—the beer—but is blind to the chainsaw. Blind trust can be like picking up a hitchhiker on a dark deserted road hoping to tap into his case of beer, but not seeing the torture device behind his back.

You must make your trust an asset to be earned by others. Let actions speak louder than words. When you allow words to disarm your trust or BS meter, you become vulnerable to attack. When you pick up hitchhikers and salivate at their case of beer, you might be blinded to their chainsaw.

One of the worst employees I ever hired was a pathological liar who stole from me. Why on earth did I hire her? She disarmed me with words. During the interview process she told me that she sang in the church choir and was a religious woman. While I didn't ask anything pertaining to religion, she assumed that I assigned honesty to religion. She was right, and it dismantled my defenses. I hired her without verification and it took me several years to uncover the truth.

VERIFY FIRST, TRUST LATER

Former president Ronald Reagan once said, "Trust, but verify." When I hired the liar, I trusted but didn't verify. It took several robberies, video cameras, and public record searches to uncover the truth. I verified too late and it cost me.

The most egregious cases of trust are our financial system. Bernard Madoff perpetrated the largest Ponzi scheme ever, and billions of dollars were lost. How does one man siphon billions from millions? Unverified trust. Thousands trusted Madoff and thousands failed to verify. Those who did verify didn't invest and some even blew the whistle. We are a trusting people and we want to believe the best. We want to believe in fairy tales and happily ever after. We want to believe that for two easy payments of \$39.95, we can make millions investing in no-money-down real estate.

When I started my entrepreneurial career fresh out of college, I trusted everyone. I bought all kinds of crazy schemes that promised me a road to wealth. What happens when you trust everyone? You get burned. You get lazy. You hire criminals. When you trust everyone, you engage in business opportunities that violate the Commandment of Control. You allow others to dictate your financial road trip. And when that happens, you crash and burn. There is only one person you can blindly trust in this world, and that is *you*.

Why so cynical? If you don't understand now, you will later. *When you serve millions, you come in contact with millions.* Only then will you understand the essence of the consumer/producer equation. Your eyes will be opened to how many people will go the extra mile to try to screw you. There is no place safe from liars, con artists, thieves, and crooks. These people commiserate in the least likely of